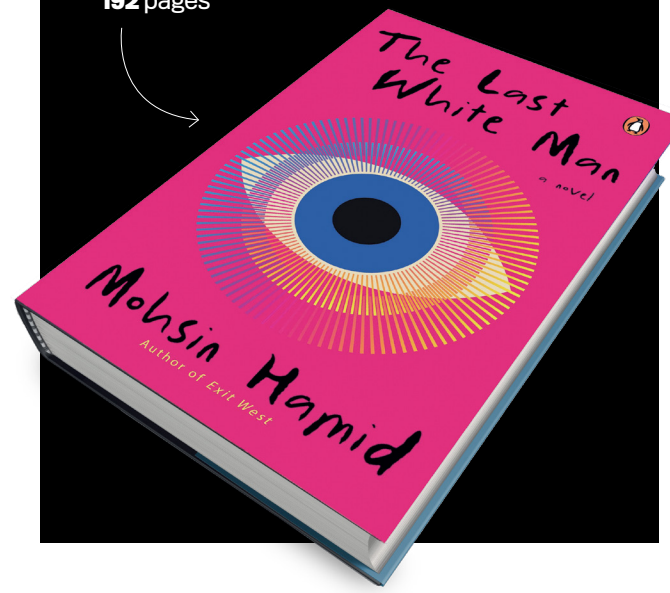
THE LAST WHITE MAN
by Mohsin Hamid
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
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A fable written in stark prose may sound forbidding just now, as we face bleak prospects for our society, our intelligence and our humanity. But Mohsin Hamid's new novel, *The Last White Man*, surprisingly leads us in the direction of peace and hope. It has been called 'Kafkaesque', evidently for its opening scene, in which the white protagonist Anders wakes up one morning to find that he is now dark-skinned. It is also Kafkaesque in its austerity. Only two characters are named, our newly brown Anders and the woman he sometimes sleeps with, Oona. There is little dialogue or expansive physical description. The unnamed setting may be Oslo, or some town in Maine, or any place in which whites are the majority and yet afraid for the future of their tribe.

Anders struggles to make sense of what has happened to him, first hiding from the world and then finally reaching for help. He encounters indifference and fear, but also unexpected sympathy. Gradually, he discovers that other people are similarly browning, everyone in the world, in fact, or in his world. Whether because of the change or in spite of it, his transactions with Oona grow into love, and they both forge deeper connections with their parents.

Through its simple premise, the novel explores our fears of being challenged, outnumbered and eventually replaced by another kind. "To me, this is something that is not a phenomenon uniquely attached to whiteness," says Hamid. "I think it's something that is attached to identity all over the world. So many people in India are clearly alarmed by a sense of a kind of Hindu identity being lost, and it's resulting in a particular kind of politics. Similarly, we see in many Muslim-majority countries people who feel the loss of a sort of Muslimness, and the attraction to people who will restore it."

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This nostalgic politics, as he puts it, imagines a glorious past, idealises it, and then fantasises about restoring it. We might add that those fantasies often lead to fear and violence. In the novel, fear turns people into hoarders, rioters and armed militiamen, capable of savagery. But Hamid takes us further to what might happen if we were able to get past our sense of loss. There could be love, children, and a brighter future.

The idea of the novel took hold, Hamid recalls, when he realised that the pre-9/11 world in which he was treated as partially white, facing "pretty minor" discriminations, was never coming back. He felt at first a profound sense of loss. "And then I thought, is this something I should want back? Was I instead kind of complicit in a system which—now that I could see it from the outside in a way—I should be very, very careful about wanting to be complicit in?... So that, I suppose, eventually led me to the idea of this book where a man...had thought of himself as white and then he wakes up and suddenly he isn't."

The construct of race, Hamid points out, was invented in recent centuries. "It will probably disappear in a few centuries. And so I thought what I would do is, instead of waiting a few centuries, let's imagine it happening in a year instead of 500 years."

The very austerity of the novel calls attention to its form, and we, as readers, seem to be meant to analyse and think about what might happen if that most common binary—white versus black—were to be erased. Hamid has taken the opportunity that only a novel can give "to move away from dialogue and physical description and that kind of specificity, and more into interiority and into gaps". As readers, we register, with Anders, the things that remain the same—the cracks in the bathroom tile, the weight that he can lift at the gym. We register the reactions of people who see him at the shops and on the street, and we wonder whether we are imagining more reactions than actually exist. But *The Last White Man* retains the emotional force of a novel, and Hamid's characters take on more life than we might expect, particularly Anders' father. When he first sees his changed son, he is baffled, but he responds with grief and help. That encounter is like the first letting in of light in what seemed like a dark future. When Oona's mother, among the last to reconcile herself to this new world, tries to explain to her granddaughter the thing—the whiteness—that is gone, we can feel compassion for her loss. After all, what if she had been the last Aborigine? That Hamid is able to raise that feeling speaks to the power of his writing. ■

–Latha Anantharaman